



M E T E O R A

AMUSE BOUCHE

trout, pineapple, spiced oil,
and kelp chips

JOB'S TEAR

cachucha pepper confit, smoked almond cream,
passion fruit and aji amarillo juice,
pineapple buds

STRIPED BASS

caramelized honey, heirloom banana, turnip,
roasted kelp made into cloud, Thai chili

DRY-AGED DUCK

grilled apricot made in to paste,
crispy chicken skin and sunflower seed,
cos lettuce, mille feuille of lettuce, green peppercorn puree
heirloom sesame labneh, sauce of tamarind and aji panca,
sweet potato naan with black lava salt

WILD AMAZONIAN CACAO

cacao ganache, andean grains, young coconut,
snow of cucumber and coconut

PAPAYA

zest of lime, tonka bean



Ever since my memorable experience at Vespertine, I grow increasingly intrigued by Meteora. Its relatively remote location keeps me hesitant, but serendipity strikes today when I find myself at the TCL Chinese Theatre for *Mission Impossible: The Final Reckoning*. With Meteora just a short distance away, I make a last-minute reservation, ready to finally explore what it has to offer. The interior design couldn't be more different from Vespertine, yet both spaces channel the elemental force of nature in distinct ways. At Meteora, vines and intricately woven wooden structures transport me to Mexico, evoking a sense of unfiltered connection to the natural world. Unlike the otherworldly abstraction of Vespertine, Meteora's aesthetic feels more grounded, more pristine, almost as if returning to nature itself.

Because it's a weekday, the restaurant offers a shorter four-course menu alongside a longer seven-course one. The former comes with numerous supplement options, which, while offering flexibility, also hint at a more commercial approach. I opt for the pure four-course experience, declining all add-ons, only to realize that doing so means relinquishing any choice entirely. Before the official menu begins, a complimentary offering from the kitchen arrives: a single "sushi" bite. This unconventional nigiri features trout, pineapple, spiced oil, and kelp chips. The rice is replaced by pineapple, and soy sauce by a thick spiced oil. The oil, though only mildly spicy, feels weighty, its richness amplified by the heat, an odd choice to begin a summer menu. The trout itself is understated but of acceptable quality. The pineapple is grilled, mellowing its acidity and enhancing its sweetness, yet when paired with the trout, the harmony remains elusive. Interestingly, the chili-laced oil and sweet pineapple recall a familiar Mexican flavor pairing, though in this context, it struggles to find its footing.



The first real course on the menu is titled job's tear, and what immediately catches the eye is, of course, the namesake grain, a staple native to Southeast Asia. Nutty and reminiscent of barley, the grains offer a pleasant chewiness, further enhanced by a gentle fire-grill that deepens their bite. They arrive nestled in a composition that includes a cachucha pepper confit and a smoked almond cream. Just before serving, the dish is finished tableside with a drizzle of passion fruit and ají amarillo juice. Tucked discreetly among the grains are delicate pineapple buds, which surprisingly taste much like chamomile, floral, grassy, and subtly soothing.

The cachucha pepper brings a mild heat, layered with sweet, grassy, fruity, and smoky notes. Once confited, it takes on a gentle flavor profile. Together with the mild acidity from the passion fruit and ají amarillo juice, it pairs seamlessly with the grain's earthiness. The smoked almond cream acts as a cohesive force, less a bold statement and more a gentle binder, harmonizing the dish's diverse elements into a balanced, almost meditative experience.



The second course features striped bass from Baja California, grilled over Binchōtan, a high-quality Japanese charcoal known for its clean, intense heat. Beside the fish rests what the chef describes as a cloud of roasted kelp, and beneath this cloud lies something of a surprise: tender wedges of turnip, each bearing the unmistakable kiss of fire. Nestled against them are slices of heirloom baby banana, joined by caramelized honey and a touch of Thai chili.

I begin with the accompaniments, and I must say, the cloud is nothing short of remarkable, ethereally light in texture yet profoundly rich in flavor. The turnips, softened within and lightly charred on the surface, carry a beautiful smokiness that plays against the kelp's umami. The addition of banana is unexpected, but it works, perhaps a nod to the frequent use of plantains in Mexican cuisine. The Thai chili adds a fiery intensity that enlivens the dish, though for my palate, it verges on excessive. Turning back to the fish itself: having experienced the flawless Binchōtan-grilled kinmedai at Vespertine, the bass here inevitably feels like a step down. Still, the aroma of the skin is deeply appealing, and while the fish may lack the same finesse, the overall composition is well-considered and satisfying.



At Meteora, the pacing between courses is remarkably brisk. Before I know it, the main course is placed before me: seven-day dry-aged duck from upstate New York. This is a complex dish. Beside the duck lies a mixture of crispy chicken skin and sunflower seeds, set atop a mound of grilled apricot that's been reduced into a paste. Nearby, a single leaf of raw Cos lettuce rests above a layered, cooked mille-feuille of lettuce, accompanied by a spoonful of heirloom sesame labneh. At the edge of the plate sits a lone green dot, seemingly disconnected from the rest of the composition. Only after asking do I learn it's a green peppercorn purée. At the table, the server pours over a sauce made from tamarind and ají panca to complete the presentation.

The tamarind and ají panca sauce is easily the standout element: vibrant, tangy, and well-balanced. Unfortunately, the duck itself falls short: it lacks depth of flavor, and the skin is inadequately rendered. In contrast, the combination of crispy chicken skin, sunflower seed, and grilled apricot paste is excellent. Deeply savory, subtly sweet, and texturally satisfying. The lettuce components make conceptual sense, adding a vegetal lightness, but the heirloom sesame labneh feels misplaced. Its dense, tangy yogurt flavor imposes itself rather than integrates, disrupting the otherwise careful balance. As for the green peppercorn purée, I remain puzzled. It adds little and feels like an afterthought in an already crowded composition.

The dish also comes with a side of sweet potato naan topped with black volcano salt, which, while pleasant in texture, tastes entirely unremarkable. Altogether, this feels like a low-budget echo of the quail course at Vespertine. That quail's texture, and the unforgettable flavor of its accompanying donut, now seem all the more elusive, perhaps never to be matched again.



The final dessert course arrives swiftly. At the center of the plate rests a ganache crafted from wild Amazonian cacao, encircled by cacao nibs, young coconut, and a medley of Andean grains, nutrient-dense staples cultivated in South America for centuries. Then, in a theatrical flourish, the server stages a snowfall: cucumber and coconut snow gently drifts over the dish, blanketing it in white.

The elegant plating is quickly obscured, though the resulting expanse of soft whiteness offers its own quiet, minimalist beauty. The ganache itself is a highlight, boldly salted, deeply savory, and perfectly calibrated to counterbalance sweetness with a rich umami undertone. Yet as the snow melts and the grains blend in, their textures fade into blurriness. The entire composition soon dissolves into a uniform, porridge-like paste. By the final spoonful, the dessert feels monotone and inert. Its early promise giving way to a lack of contrast and structural clarity. For all its visual poetry, the dish ultimately lacks the form and finesse to be considered a truly accomplished dessert.



Just as I thought the meal had come to a close, the server brought out an unexpected final gesture: a small bowl of ice, topped with a single slice of papaya, lightly dusted with lime zest and a whisper of tonka bean.

To be honest, I find myself preferring the papaya in its natural state. Its sweetness rich, fragrant, and full. The lime zest, while bright, adds an acidity I'm not convinced the fruit needs, and the tonka bean is so faint it barely registers. Still, compared to Vespertine, which surprisingly omits the petit fours, this small offering of fruit is a pleasant surprise: a quiet epilogue that gently returns me to the warmth of Mexico, and to the simplicity of nature itself.



